GDE-55179
Revision ID:0
Effective Date: 05/06/26

Guide

Project Number: 53702

National Reactor Innovation Center Nuclear Energy Launch Pad Application and Evaluation Manual

Idaho National Laboratory

The INL is a U.S. Department of Energy National Laboratory
operated by Battelle Energy Alliance.

REVISION LOG

Rev.	Date	Affected Pages	Revision Description
0	05/06/26	All	See DCR 741872. New issue.

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1. INTRODUCTION

This document explains the process for applying to the National Reactor Innovation Center's (NRIC) Nuclear Energy Launch Pad Request for Applications (RFA) and outlines the criteria used to evaluate and select applications. NRIC will administer this process on behalf of and in collaboration with the United States Department of Energy (DOE). Nuclear Energy Launch Pad has two pathways via Launch Pad Idaho National Laboratory (INL) "Launch Pad INL" or Launch Pad United States of America (U.S.A.) "Launch Pad U.S.A." The RFA is meant to be a stand-alone document, however, this guide supplements the information contained in the RFA.

Applicants are responsible for all costs associated with preparing and submitting their application, as well as costs incurred by NRIC, INL, and DOE in support of their participation in the Nuclear Energy Launch Pad initiative after selection into the Program.

2. ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

The successful execution of the Nuclear Energy Launch Pad initiative requires clear alignment of roles and responsibilities across all participating organizations. The following section defines the specific responsibilities of each key stakeholder — the DOE Office of Nuclear Energy, DOE-Idaho, the National Reactor Innovation Center (NRIC), and the Developer — to ensure transparency, accountability, and efficient coordination throughout the application, selection, and project execution process. While each organization plays a distinct role, their efforts are closely integrated to provide Developers with the support, authority, and infrastructure needed to advance their technology from first authorization through commercial licensing. Roles and responsibilities listed may be adjusted to best accommodate the Developers needs if appropriate and at the discretion of DOE and NRIC.

2.1 DOE Office of Nuclear Energy

DOE's Office of Nuclear Energy provides overall Launch Pad Program direction and authority including.

- Approve issuance of RFA and subsequent project selections.
- Establishing and overseeing a Concierge Team to provide senior level decision-making to remove barriers and mitigate issues that the assigned Technical Point of Contact for each applicant is unable to provide.

2.1.1 Launch Pad Concierge Team

2.1.1.1 Membership

- NE-5 Deputy Assistant Secretary (Chair for Concierge Team)
- NRIC Federal Program Manager
- NRIC Director
- NE-4 Deputy Assistant Secretary
- DOE-GC
- DOE Manager & Safety Basis Approval Authority
- INL Associate Laboratory Director (ALD) for Nuclear Science & Technology (NS&T)
- INL MFC ALD
- Launch Pad Program Manager

2.1.1.2 Responsibilities

- The Concierge Team has the appropriate authority to execute actions across Launch Pad with the primary focus on providing senior level decision-making to remove barriers and mitigate issues that the assigned NRIC TPMs for each applicant are unable to provide.
- The Concierge Team will maintain status across all Launch Pad projects.
- The Concierge Team will maintain status on the results of actions the Concierge Team and/or the NRIC TPMs have taken to facilitate the successful execution for the applicant deployments.

- The Concierge Team will provide expedited review and action upon prompting from the NRIC TPM as to a barrier and/or issue that the NRIC TPM and/or the Developer is unable to resolve and whose consequence could negatively impact Developer's planned schedule for advanced nuclear technology project deployment.

- The DOE Other Transaction Authority (OTA) POC will field and facilitate the NRIC TPM barrier and issue identification and resolution.

2.2 Idaho Operations Office

2.2.1 Idaho Operations Office Roles and Responsibilities

- Full Federal stewardship for the Idaho National Laboratory (INL):
  - Head of Contracting Authority & Performance Based Oversight for INL Management & Operating Contractor
  - Agreement Official authorities for Other Transaction Authority (OTA) Agreements from Reactor & Fuel Line Pilot Program and Launch Pad approved applicants
  - In concert with NE-HQ recommendation for approvals for Reactor and Fuel Line Pilot Program and Launch Pad approved applicants.
- Head of Field Element responsibilities as described in DOE orders, guides and Standards and through delegated authority:
  - Safety Basis Approval Authority
  - Startup Approval Authority as described in NE O 425.1
  - Authorizing Official for Cybersecurity
  - Officially Designated Federal Security Authority.

2.2.2 DOE-ID Key Subordinate Roles and Responsibilities

2.2.2.1 DOE-ID Other Transaction Authority Agreement Official

- Supports development of Other Transaction Authority Agreement
- Head of Contracting Authority & Performance Based Oversight for INL Management & Operating Contractor
- Agreement Official authorities for Other Transaction Authority (OTA) Agreements from Reactor & Fuel Line Pilot Program and Launch Pad approved applicants
- In concert with NE-HQ recommendation for approvals for Pilot Program and Launch Pad approved applicants.

2.2.2.2 Head of Field Element responsibilities as described in DOE orders, guides, and standards and through delegated authority

- Safety Basis Approval Authority
- Startup Approval Authority as described in NE O 425.1
- Authorizing Official for Cybersecurity
- Officially Designated Federal Security Authority.

2.2.2.3 DOE-ID Other Transaction Authority Agreement Point of Contact

- Manages and coordinates contributory funds and resources for regulatory support for STD-1271 Nuclear Safety Design Agreement (NSDA), Preliminary Documented Safety Analysis (PDSA), Documented Safety Analysis (DSA), DOE Readiness

- Support identification and management of Long-Term Oversight (Facility Representatives (FRs), Subject Matter Experts (SMEs), Safeguards and Security (S&S)) on OTA scope of work

- Coordinates with NRIC TPM for authorization and regulatory support review

- Maintains awareness of Developer Milestones and provides acceptance of OTA deliverables in concert with review by NRIC TPM as delineated in the OTA

- Ensures vertical and horizontal integration and awareness with DOE-ID, NE-HQ and BEA of OTA progress

- Coordinates with Concierge Team as needed for identification and resolution of Developer issues

- Supports Launch Pad Developer application review and NE approval of NRIC project selection recommendation.

2.3 National Reactor Innovation Center

2.3.1 National Reactor Innovation Center Roles and Responsibilities

NRIC is responsible for General Program Management of Launch Pad activities including:

- Establish and maintain an integrated Launch Pad Team:
  - Membership: NRIC, DOE Office of Nuclear Energy (NE-5 & NE-4), DOE-ID and others as needed
  - Schedule recurring meetings
  - Develop an annual Launch Pad plan
  - Develop Communications Plans.
- Coordinate with other national labs and universities
- Develop, issue, and manage process for Request for Applications

- Serve as primary interface with potential applicants
- Provide a Technical Program Manager for each project selected by DOE.

2.3.2 NRIC Technical Program Manager (TPM) Roles and Responsibilities

- Primary point of contact and support to Developer
- Develop, issue, and manage Strategic Partnership Project (SPP) agreement with Developer to fund NRIC/INL's work on the project
- Negotiate sub SPP administrative Project Task Statement (PTS) and follow-on PTSs for additional Developer support needs
- Key interface for DOE OTA POC, DOE-ID, NE and BEA management
- Lead for project planning, contracting, and build out of Developer nuclear technology deployment
- Facilitate the Developer's nuclear technology deployment by providing world class communication, support, and deliverable execution
- Oversight of Developer project schedule to maintain planned baseline
- Coordinate with DOE SME & project staff on schedule for authorization review and approval and readiness reviews planning
- Produces presentations and updates appropriate for OTA POC, DOE, NE-HQ and BEA management personnel.
- Develops a shared file structure to manage submittals, deliverables and correspondence
- Routinely collaborate with other TPMs and Federal OTA POC
- Develop/schedule briefings for Concierge Team, NRIC/DOE Management and NRIC/DOE SME and Oversight resources

- Logs Developer requests and follow through to completion
- Develops, reviews and manages communication integration with DOE PA staff along with Developer for all communications, including press releases and be the facilitator for Developer communications with all NRIC, INL, and DOE resources
- Immediately communicates issues with NRIC and DOE management and utilize the Concierge Team as the solution generator if existing resources don't provide the needed outcome
- Establish communications and be local expert on Developer application, especially on milestones and deliverables
- Establish planned communications and standing meetings with both Developer, OTA POC, OTA AO and DOE-ID, NE-HQ and BEA management
- Identify who will fulfill what roles in support of Developer actions for NRIC/INL/Other Labs and DOE
- Negotiate Developer site visits to meet Developer Team, understand the Developer's nuclear technology deployment and immediately establish granularity on the Developer schedule
- Integrate immediately with the NRIC/DOE Concierge Team, DOE Authorizing Official and OTA POC
- Developer schedule & milestones – become expert in the Developer schedule, deliverables, milestones, NRIC, INL, & DOE resources needed, etc.

2.4 Developer/Applicant

2.4.1 Developer/Applicant Roles and Responsibilities

- Technology development and overall project execution
- Responsible for full funding of project:
  - Provide funding for the project and for costs incurred by DOE-ID and NRIC. DOE-ID may require contributory funds under the OTA, and NRIC/INL will be funded through the Developer SPP

- Provide funding for any facility modifications/construction

- Establish SPP agreement with NRIC

- Establish OTA with DOE as needed.

3. APPLICATION, REVIEW, AND SELECTION PROCESS

3.1 Application to Selection Process Overview

Figure 1 below illustrates the expected steps between receipt of application, through selection, contracting with NRIC and DOE, and ultimately to construction of facility. An SPP with NRIC and OTA with DOE will almost always be necessary as part of the Launch Pad Program. There may be instances such as use of existing facilities on federal land where an OTA may not be required. In those instances, NRIC and DOE will work with the Developer to find an appropriate path forward. If there are multiple projects required to reach commercialization there is no need to reapply to Launch Pad, but applicants should address this in their proposal. If multiple projects are required, then there may be a need for multiple OTAs with DOE and Project Task Statements to the SPP with NRIC.

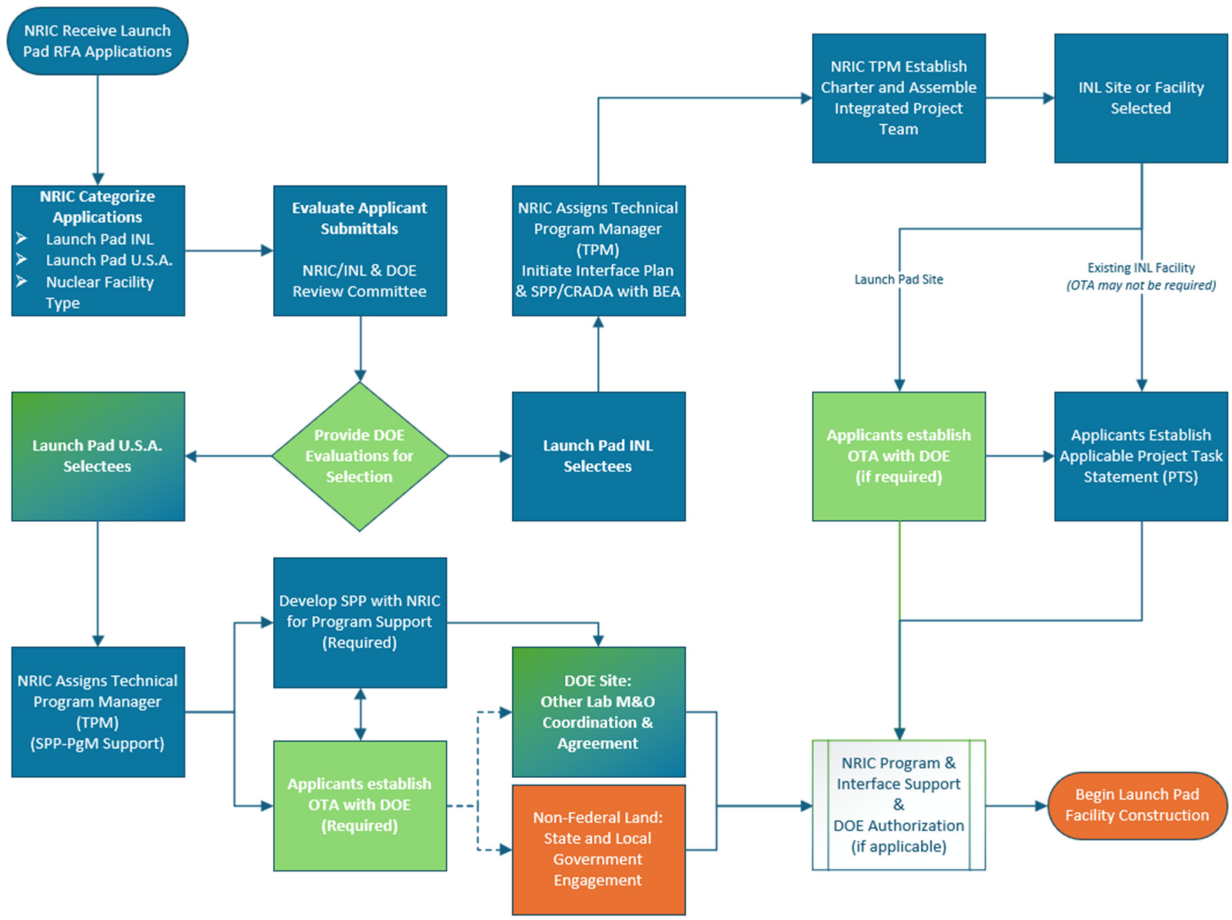

Figure 1. Process flow diagram of the application to construction process.

3.2 Summary of the NRIC Nuclear Energy Launch Pad RFA

The U.S. Department of Energy (DOE) and the National Reactor Innovation Center (NRIC) created the Nuclear Energy Launch Pad initiative to accelerate deployment of advanced nuclear technologies by providing two flexible pathways for siting, testing, and operating advanced nuclear facilities:

- Launch Pad INL: Dedicated INL land, infrastructure access, and INL Managing and Operating (M&O) contractor support.

- Launch Pad U.S.A.: Deployment on other DOE or non-Federal sites under DOE authorization.

The RFA invites private Developers to propose nuclear facilities—such as reactors, fuel cycle facilities, recycling systems, enrichment, and more—that are sufficiently mature to move into near-term construction, operation, and testing.

Facilities operate under DOE authorization rather than NRC licensing during initial deployment, enabling accelerated timelines.

Applicants must demonstrate technical maturity, nuclear material planning, execution readiness, financial resources, and a clear path to DOE authorization and eventual NRC licensing/commercialization (if applicable).

The application shall include a Technical Volume PDF file that is no more than 50 pages in length. Refer to the Nuclear Energy Launch Pad RFA for more detailed instructions on the Technical Volume submittal. The PDF file shall include a completed version of Table 1 of this guide document and the files included in the submittal should address and satisfy expectations found in Table 2 in support of the technical volume found in the RFA. Applications should include all assumptions made and provide the basis to support these assumptions.

Additionally, a separate schedule native file (e.g., XER, MPP) shall be included in the application submittal as a separate attachment and does not count towards the page limit, see Table 2 for selection expectations.

After application submission, applicants need to notify NRIC of any significant changes to Table 1 milestone dates and provide an updated schedule within five business days of gaining knowledge of the change. This ensures the Launch Pad Program maintains accurate, current information necessary for effective coordination and oversight.

3.3 External Capabilities

The NRIC Launch Pad is developing a coordinated national database of subject matter experts (SMEs) and laboratory capabilities to streamline support for advanced nuclear technology developers. This database will be located on the NRIC website. This initiative combines two parallel efforts: building a nationwide university SME network and integrating capabilities and expertise from major national laboratories. This directory captures technical expertise, research focus areas, facilities, and testing infrastructure relevant to Developers.

NRIC will make available to Developers an access point to locate national laboratory and university experts and explore laboratory resources across the national research ecosystem. This integrated approach significantly reduces the time and effort required for Developers to identify the right expertise and facilities, supporting faster, more efficient advancement of advanced nuclear technologies. Additional support include, but are not limited to:

- **Nuclear Lifecycle Innovation Campus (NLIC) Support**

  NLIC locations may support activities across the full nuclear fuel lifecycle, including fuel fabrication, enrichment, reprocessing used nuclear fuel, and disposition of waste. Indicate if you would like to be connected with NLIC for potential opportunities.

- **National Nuclear Security Administration (NNSA) Support**

  US Nuclear NEXUS: Nexus serves as a "one-stop shop" for U.S. companies seeking information or assistance from the NNSA on export controls, international safeguards, security, and proliferation resistance to support US companies pursuing international deployment. Indicate if you would like to be connected with the Nuclear NEXUS.

- **Nuclear Engineering Department Heads Organization (NEDHO) Support**

  NRIC is working with NEDHO, a professional alliance of heads (chairs) of nuclear engineering schools, departments, and programs in North America to establish a support network for Developers. NEDHO is not a government agency, although it often engages with the U.S. Department of Energy (DOE) on matters related to nuclear workforce development, reactor technology, and research funding.

Table 1. Applicant information.

Contact Info			
Company Name			
Company Address			
Main PoC & Title			
Email:		Phone:	
Technical PoC & Title			
Email:		Phone:	
Contracting PoC & Title			
Email:		Phone:	
Select Nuclear Energy Launch Pad Pathway			
Launch Pad INL ☐		*Launch Pad U.S.A.	☐
**If Launch Pad U.S.A. provide Intended project location/site:*			
Technology Overview			
Provide description of the nuclear technology being developed as part of this application.			
Provide an overview of your technology’s short- and long-term strategic vision, to include a commercialization plan after Launch Pad (be as specific as possible on your regulatory approach).			
Proposed Milestone Dates			
Receive DOE Authorization			
Start of construction			
Start of demonstration			
End of demonstration			
Closeout & decommission			

Table 2. Application technical adequacy characteristics.

Category	Characteristics of a Technically Complete Application
Technology Maturity Does the current technical maturity of the system present risks to the Applicant's schedule?	The Applicant's technology readiness plan is detailed and comprehensive. There are no significant technology maturation issues that would threaten the Applicant's readiness. The Applicant demonstrates quality and completeness in their probabilistic risk assessment, ensuring it accurately reflects the plant's design, operation, and potential risks. Technical risks and mitigation plans are manageable.
Nuclear Feedstock/Fuel Is the plan to secure nuclear feedstock/fuel at a sufficient maturity level to enable deployment?	The Applicant has an available source to supply nuclear feedstock/fuel with manageable levels of execution risk. The plan for nuclear feedstock/fuel activities (e.g., procuring, fabricating, delivering, storing, assembling, loading, ownership of used fuel, etc.) has high likelihood of success.
Waste Management and Decommissioning Does the Applicant have an adequate plan for waste management and decommissioning?	The Applicant has a credible plan for facility decommissioning and disposal or long-term management of generated wastes and used/spent fuel.
Testing & Process Line Capability Does the Applicant's proposed plan establish fundamental technological viability?	The Applicant's test plans are sufficiently developed and there is no reason to expect detailed procedures will threaten readiness for the proposed project. If test is successful, the results would establish fundamental technological viability.
Project Schedule Does the Applicant's proposed schedule have a high likelihood of meeting the desired timeline?	The Applicant's schedule is detailed, logic driven, exhaustive of all workstreams, includes credible durations, and has manageable execution risks. Some attributes of a well-developed schedule might include: Work Breakdown Structure (WBS), Activities, and Milestones from application through decommissioning. Plus, at a minimum, one additional level of detail to show activities that support major milestones. Decommissioning activities are sufficiently detailed, and the decommissioning timeline is consistent with the overall timeline for subsequent testing (e.g., shut down, cool, disconnect, remove, decontaminate, etc.). Risk analysis with mitigations considered in schedule activities, durations, and reserve.
Site Plan Does the Applicant have a site for the facility or a solid plan toward securing a site?	Site established. Letter of Intent (LOI), Memorandum of Understanding (MOU), or other documents confirming site selection is provided. If requesting a Launch Pad INL site indicate in Table 2 and provide reason/justification for the request and how being sited at INL aligns with your company's strategy.

Category	Characteristics of a Technically Complete Application
DOE Authorization Plan Does the Applicant demonstrate an understanding of the authorization process, have a robust plan to navigate it, and are there any obvious, significant authorization threats?	The authorization plan is well-described with a clear understanding of the regulator's requirements and processes. The safety-related features of the technology are unlikely to present new hazards and phenomena that the regulator is unfamiliar with evaluating.
Long-term Regulatory and Commercialization Plans Does the applicant have a long-term strategy for their technology beyond DOE Authorization. Do they have a robust plan to navigate it, and are there any obvious, significant commercialization or regulatory concerns?	The regulatory and commercialization plans are well-described with a clear understanding of the regulator's requirements and processes. The long-term strategy displays a comprehensive readiness and aligns with DOE's mission and strategy.
Funding Is the Applicant's funding sufficient to support their readiness for design, manufacturing, construction, operations, and decommissioning?	The Applicant's funding sources are secure and sufficient to execute the project through the end of testing and decommissioning. Funding is sufficient to cover the Applicant's contingency for realized risk.
Experience & Capabilities	Does the applicant possess the suite of needed capabilities, experience, and network to be successful on the needed timeline.
Master Document and Deliverable List (MDDL) Does the Applicant understand what documents and deliverables need to be developed to support the reactor experiment project?	The MDDL identifies most of the documents that will ultimately be needed to support the reactor operations and experiment execution. The MDDL is organized. The MDDL indicates specific information such as document number, revision, title, and maturity level.

3.4 Application Evaluation

Applications will be scored in accordance with the rubric outlined in Table 3. Applications that receive higher scores will have a greater chance of being selected for the Nuclear Energy Launch Pad initiative near the requested timeline by the applicant. The risk associated with applicants meeting their proposed schedules will be assessed to ensure that Launch Pad resources are allocated efficiently. DOE will make final Launch Pad selections based on DOE's capability to support the required workload, as well as the maturity and overall quality of the submitted applications.

Table 3. Application score card.

Category	Characteristics of a Low Score	Characteristics of a High Score	*Score (Total 100)
Technology Maturity Does the current technical maturity of the system present risks to the Applicant's schedule?	The applicant's technology readiness plan is a high-level summary (e.g., tasks to resolve technical uncertainties or to increase TRL are not identified). There appear to be several key design or technology concerns that, if not successfully addressed, would threaten project readiness.	The applicant's technology readiness plan is detailed and comprehensive. There are no significant technology maturation issues that would threaten the Applicant's project readiness. Technical risks and mitigation plans are manageable.	(0-10)
Nuclear Feedstock/Fuel Is the plan to secure nuclear feedstock/fuel at a sufficient maturity level to enable deployment?	The applicant does not have a clear fuel source. Activities associated with sourcing and handling fuel have not been developed. The applicant's plan to secure and qualify fuel (to an appropriate level for a reactor experiment) is a clear risk to the project milestones.	The applicant has an available source to supply fuel with manageable levels of execution risk. The plan for fuel activities (e.g., procuring, fabricating, delivering, storing, assembling, loading, ownership of used fuel, etc.) has high likelihood of success.	(0-10)
Waste Management and Decommissioning Does the Applicant have an adequate plan for waste management and decommissioning?	The applicant lacks defined waste pathways, has unclear or undeveloped plans for handling or disposing of radioactive or hazardous materials, and provides no credible decommissioning approach, creating significant execution, compliance, and schedule risks.	The applicant provides a clear, mature plan identifying all waste streams, defined pathways for handling and disposal, and a credible decommissioning strategy aligned with regulatory expectations, demonstrating low execution risk and a strong likelihood of compliant, successful project closeout.	(0-10)
Testing & Process Line Capability Does the Applicant's proposed plan establish fundamental technological viability?	The applicant's test plans are incomplete, lack defined methods or readiness, or contain uncertainties that could impede timely execution. The approach does not clearly show how testing would establish technological viability, creating significant risk to project success.	The applicant provides well-developed, technically sound test plans with clear objectives, methods, and readiness. No foreseeable procedural gaps threaten execution, and successful testing would credibly demonstrate fundamental technological viability with low risk to schedule or outcomes.	(0-10)

Category	Characteristics of a Low Score	Characteristics of a High Score	*Score (Total 100)
Project Schedule Does the applicant's proposed schedule have a high likelihood of meeting the desired timeline?	The applicant's schedule is high-level, missing detail in key workstreams, with several durations lacking credible basis and showing significant negative float. Numerous schedule risks remain unaddressed. Decommissioning activities are summarized only broadly or presented on a timeline inconsistent with the overall project schedule Some attributes that might indicate an immature schedule include: • Activities do not correspond to the WBS and MDDL. • Risk analysis of the schedule has not been performed or incorporated. • Monte Carlo analysis and quantified confidence level for timely completion not performed or incorporated.	The applicant provides a detailed, logic-based schedule covering all workstreams with credible durations, adequate margin, and manageable risks. Decommissioning activities are clearly defined, and their timeline aligns with the overall project schedule, including shutdown, cooldown, disconnection, removal, and decontamination steps. Some attributes of a well-developed schedule might include: • Activities and their decomposition correspond to the WBS and MDDL. • Risk analysis with mitigations considered in schedule activities, durations, and reserve. • Monte Carlo analysis and quantified confidence level for timely completion.	(0-5)
Site Plan Does the Applicant have a site for the facility or a solid plan toward securing a site?	The applicant has not yet detailed how their technology aligns with Launch Pad's interface requirements. Several of the interfaces will require significant effort by INL, or the applicant's part, to accommodate and may challenge the delivery schedule.	The applicant's understanding of Launch Pad's interface requirements is mature. There are no obvious challenges associated with delivering within those requirements.	(0-10)
DOE Authorization Plan Does the applicant demonstrate an understanding of the authorization process, have a robust plan to navigate it, and are there any obvious, significant authorization threats?	The authorization plan is light on details and is missing important features (e.g., safety, quality, and environmental, etc.). The safety-related features may present new phenomena that the regulator is unfamiliar with evaluating. At a screening level, there may be environmental impacts that could threaten NEPA timelines.	The authorization plan is well-described with a clear understanding of the regulator's requirements and processes. The safety-related features of the technology are unlikely to present new hazards and phenomena that the regulator is unfamiliar with evaluating. At a screening level, the environmental impacts do not appear to be materially more challenging than other reactor technologies.	(0-10)

Category	Characteristics of a Low Score	Characteristics of a High Score	*Score (Total 100)
Long-term Regulatory and Commercialization Plans Does the applicant have a long-term strategy for their technology beyond DOE Authorization. Do they have a robust plan to navigate it, and are there any obvious, significant commercialization or regulatory concerns?	The long-term regulatory and commercialization plans are light on detail and do not demonstrate a clear pathway beyond DOE Authorization. The applicant shows limited understanding of future regulatory requirements, market entry barriers, or key milestones necessary to support deployment. Significant regulatory or commercialization risks are evident—such as unclear licensing strategy, unaddressed market constraints, or undeveloped business or deployment models—and the application does not provide credible mitigation strategies. The long-term strategy does not appear aligned with DOE's mission, broader market realities, or known regulatory processes.	The long-term regulatory and commercialization plans are well-developed, clearly articulated, and demonstrate an in-depth understanding of post-authorization regulatory requirements and market pathways. The applicant provides a credible, phased strategy for commercialization, including key milestones, market entry approach, supply chain considerations, and long-term deployment planning. Potential regulatory and commercialization risks are identified, and the applicant provides realistic, well-reasoned mitigation strategies. The long-term strategy displays strong technical and organizational readiness and is well-aligned with DOE's mission, broader energy ecosystem needs, and existing regulatory frameworks.	(0-10)
Funding Is the Applicant's funding sufficient to support their readiness for design, manufacturing, construction, operations, and decommissioning? (See Note below)	Funding is insufficient or sources are undetermined. The applicant's funding is materially contingent on interim development outcomes that carry high risk.	The applicant's funding sources are secure and sufficient to execute the project through the end of testing and decommissioning. Funding is sufficient to cover the applicant's contingency for realized risk.	(0-10)
Experience and Capabilities Does the applicant possess the suite of needed capabilities, experience, and network to be successful on the needed timeline?	The applicant has not demonstrated past performance in similar R&D efforts. The applicant is still standing up important parts of its execution infrastructure (e.g., leadership, QA, project management, design, supply chain, etc.). The relationship between the applicant and key supply chain partners is at an early stage.	The applicant has a demonstrated history of executing similar R&D projects. The applicant's internal processes are well-established and time-tested. The applicant has a robust network of supply chain partners and has been collaboratively working with them to progress the technology manufacturing readiness.	(0-10)

Category	Characteristics of a Low Score	Characteristics of a High Score	*Score (Total 100)
Master Document and Deliverable List (MDDL) Does the applicant understand what documents and deliverables need to be developed to support the reactor experiment project?	The MDDL only identifies a small number of the documents, or provides category descriptions rather than specific items, that will ultimately be needed to support the Launch Pad project. The MDDL is not clearly organized.	The MDDL identifies most of the documents that will ultimately be needed to support the Launch Pad project. The MDDL is organized. The MDDL indicates specific information such as document number, revision, title, and maturity level.	(0-5)
*A grade of zero in any category will disqualify an application from advancing to the Selection Committee.			

NOTE: *As DOE invests in critical infrastructure and funds critical and emerging technology areas, DOE also considers possible vectors of undue foreign influence in evaluating risk. As part of the research, technology, and economic security risk review, DOE may contact the applicant and/or proposed project team members for additional information to inform the review. This risk review is conducted separately from the technical merit review. If high risks are identified and cannot be sufficiently mitigated, DOE may elect to not select the applicant.*

4. AGREEMENT STRATEGY

Launch Pad applicants, if selected to participate, will work with NRIC under Battelle Energy Alliance, LLC (BEA), M&O contractor for the INL, and the DOE to finalize the agreements needed to support the proposed scope of work. The type and number of agreements will depend on the scope of work, the deployment location, and the plan for construction and operation of the facility.

Selected applicants will require NRIC programmatic support, site services, and/or technical support and will be expected to enter into a Strategic Partnership Project (SPP) agreement with BEA. An SPP is a fee-for-service agreement mechanism that allows non-Federal entities to obtain defined work from a national laboratory using its facilities, equipment, or personnel. For Launch Pad purposes, this agreement will support activities such as programmatic oversight, site services, engineering and safety analysis, and related technical assistance as required.

Selected applicants that will construct and operate a facility will also require an Other Transaction Authority (OTA) Agreement with DOE to support construction, authorization, and operation of the facility. Within Launch Pad, the OTA will serve as the primary agreement vehicle between DOE and the participant.

Figure 1 outlines the circumstances in which an OTA, an SPP, or both agreements are required. In general, applicants using an existing facility under BEA design authority without constructing and operating a facility may require only an SPP, while applicants constructing and operating a new facility will require an OTA with DOE and require an SPP with BEA for programmatic oversight and support services.

As part of agreement finalization, applicants should also expect to undergo applicable security reviews and as required, reviews relating to Foreign Ownership, Control, or Influence (FOCI). The scope of these reviews will depend on the proposed work scope, the sensitivity of the information or materials involved, and the location where project activities will occur.

5. DOE AUTHORIZATION PROCESS AND INITIATION ACTIVITIES

Selected Launch Pad participants shall follow DOE-STD-1271, “Authorization Pathway for Nuclear Facilities,” which establishes the Department of Energy Office of Nuclear Energy framework for authorization of eligible nuclear facilities.

This process begins with the Developer’s development of a Nuclear Safety Design Agreement (NSDA), which establishes alignment between DOE and the Developer regarding applicable requirements, the safety analysis methodology, design expectations, and the anticipated regulatory engagement approach. As the project advances and the design reaches an appropriate level of maturity, the Developer shall prepare and submit a Preliminary Documented Safety Analysis (PDSA). The PDSA provides the initial integrated safety basis for DOE review and supports evaluation of the proposed design, identified hazards, and the safety functions of key structures, systems, and components.

As the design is finalized and reflected in the as-built facility configuration, the Developer must then prepare the final Documented Safety Analysis (DSA) and associated Technical Safety Requirements (TSRs), which together establish the approved safety basis for operation. Authorization to commence operations is contingent upon DOE approval of the applicable safety basis documents, completion of required readiness activities, and DOE startup authorization. In parallel with safety basis development, Developers should also plan for the broader set of siting and project-enabling activities, including NEPA review, permitting, site access or leasing arrangements, hazard categorization, emergency management, security planning, waste management, operational program development, training, maintenance, and configuration management. DOE-STD-1271 is the governing document for DOE Authorization and supersedes this GDE-55179 if conflicting information exists.

For Launch Pad participants operating under an OTA Agreement, the participants will submit the relevant authorization and safety basis documentation directly to DOE in accordance with the applicable review process. Where a project is conducted within a BEA managed facility at Launch Pad INL and not under an OTA, BEA serves as the Design Authority and will submit the required documentation to DOE on behalf of the project.

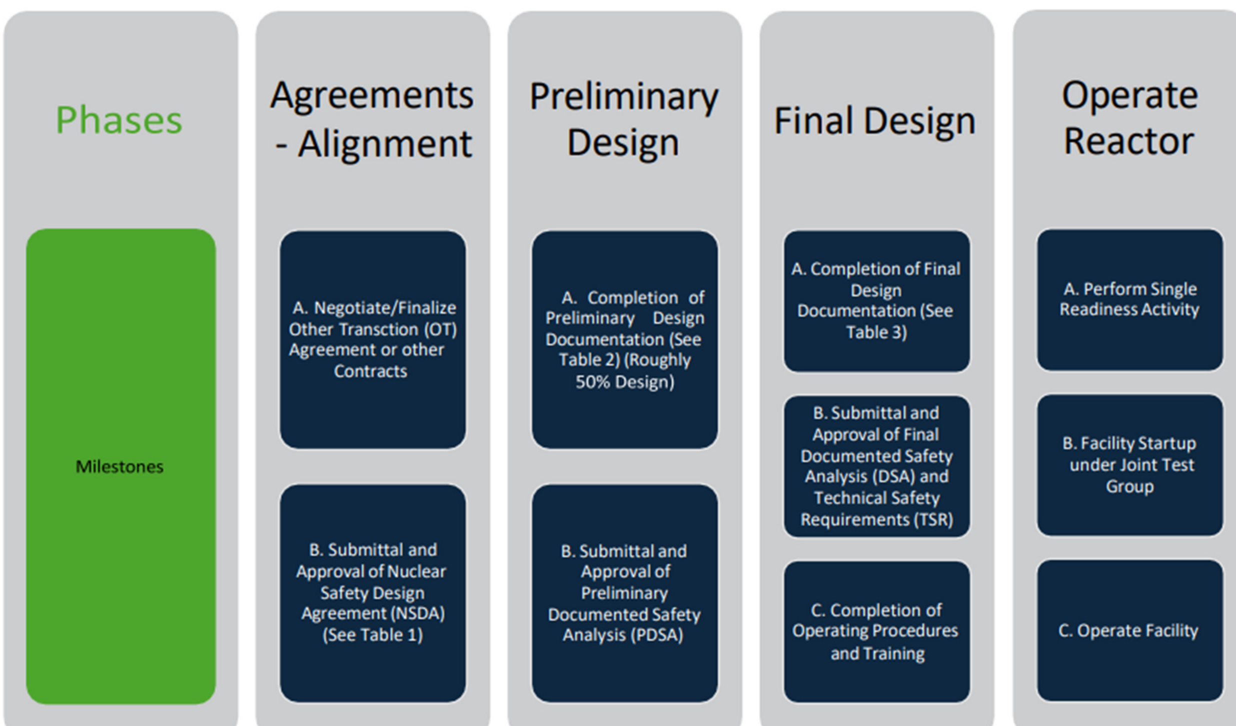

Figure 2. Summary of DOE authorization process for nuclear facilities.

6. RESOURCES AVAILABLE FOR ADDITIONAL SUPPORT

NRIC plans to maintain a dedicated section on the NRIC.gov webpage serving as a centralized resource hub for Launch Pad. The site will include points of contact at participating national laboratories and universities, a listing of available support services, and individual fact sheets for each participating national laboratory. In addition, the site will contain a directory of subject matter experts including nuclear safety, criticality safety, safeguards and security, emergency management, quality assurance, and environmental compliance, along with direct links to available resources and support tools. Developers are encouraged to utilize whatever resources, organizations, and expertise they see fit to advance their project. The listings and information provided on NRIC's webpage are intended solely as a convenience to Developers and do not constitute an endorsement by NRIC, INL, or DOE of any organization, service, nor individual. Developers should contact NRIC with any additional questions.